Frosta Alone

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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Frosta Alone

by Bereavedbuckle

Summary

The princesses have left Etheria for a diplomatic mission but Frosta was left behind. After several pranks, she's not quite ready to apologise for, she realises she is the highest ranking monarch left on the planet. There's no limit to what she can do and with noone to tell her no anymore she has the best fun she's ever had.

That is until she overhears two criminals bragging about all things they will steal while the princesses are away. Not on her watch. This war just got started...

COMPLETED

Chapter 1: No princess left behind... Again.

Frosta moved through the crowd hiding behind crates and trunks wherever she could, dodging and dashing for cover where she could not. Her small body was perfectly adapted to crouching low, giving her more dexterity. Plus no-one was actually looking for her at the moment. She moved with an air of mischievous intent, spotting her quarry on the edge of the clearing. She moved closer and ducked down behind an assortment of crates about to get loaded aboard the nearby spaceship. Chuckling to herself, eyes narrowed, a small smile spread across her lips as she checked her position. Peering over the crates she spied Scorpia and Perfuma having an intimate chat. One of those boring grown-up private talks. She could tell "kissing" would happen shortly if she didn't do something fast.

She clutched the opaque glassy jewel in her fist and lifted it to her mouth, her eyes never leaving her prey for a moment.

"Force Captain! Report to the docking station immediately!" Catra's ruthless vocals rang out clear and loud across the distance. The effect was immediate and Scorpia stood to attention; claw raised in a formal salute.

"Yessir!" She said and without a backwards glance raced off towards the hanger leaving a perplexed Perfuma alone. Frosta laughed so hard she snorted, her eyes tearing up in glee. It was short lived.

"Just what do you think you are doing?" Pertuma's head loomed large above the young princess, the flowery woman's face a picture of uninhibited rage for once, hands on hips. "You should be ashamed of yourself Princess Frosta, playing on others' feelings the way you just did. I want you to go and apologize to Scorpia this instant."

Frosta, still doubled up laughing in her crouched position merely pointed at Perfuma and tried to steady her breath.

"You... Your face... It's priceless."

Perfuma’s glare hardened and Frosta could tell the conversation was about to plummet into the icy depths of a glacier in the Northern Reaches if she didn’t at least appear to be apologetic. She stood up, her laughter dissipating into a soft chuckle and moved towards Darla to find Scorpia, 'apologise' and make things right. Thankfully Perfuma hadn't asked how she'd mimicked the cat girls voice, the rage clearly getting the better of her for once and Frosta didn't offer an explanation. Double Trouble’s little gift to her was to be their secret and one she didn’t plan to give up easily. She also deigned not to tell the flower princess she'd already tricked Sea Hawk into singing a shanty to Mermista about burps and other bodily functions. That was a triumph of ingenuity achieved by "Bow" giving dating advice from inside his tent. She’d kept Sea Hawk from entering by telling him that she “Bow” had a contagious disease she couldn’t name but didn’t want to pass on to anyone. The sea shanty had been fun. Mermista had slapped her boyfriend and stomped off in a fury.

Frosta reached the spaceship and marvelled at the size of it and all the activity going on around her. She spotted Scorpia not far off talking to Catra. They were deep in discussion. As she watched, their eyes gravitated towards her and they shared a look of annoyance. Frosta certainly wasn’t going over there now.

Glimmer stood at the bottom of the loading bay ramp ticking off supplies as they were loaded into the ship. Darla was nearly ready to go and the tannoy had requested all passengers to board several times although only a handful had actually acceded to the request so far. Perfuma reached Scorpia and Catra and the three older women looked at Frosta expectantly. Clearly, she was supposed to apologise. Instead she stuck her tongue out at them from behind Glimmer’s back eliciting three glares and a shaken head. The three women entered Darla ready for take off and Frosta was left with Glimmer.

Glimmer sighed as she turned around and found the ice princess hiding behind her back.

“Frosta, what are you doing here? You’re supposed to be on board for take-off. We’re leaving for the planet Shireen as soon as I’ve finished this inventory.” She groaned and raised her eyes skywards as she considered the amount of paperwork she still had to do for this trip alone. Hopefully there would be time for rest and relaxation at some point alongside the diplomatic reasons for the visit.

Frosta thought fast, smiling and saluting with pride, "All weapons accounted for, Queen Glimmer."

Glimmer groaned and pinched the space between her eyebrows.

"We don't need weapons Frosta" she said, a sharp edge to her voice from exhaustion. She’d need a break after this trip. Frosta froze at the words but Glimmer had looked back at her clipboard. "This is a peaceful envoy. Are you all packed?"

Frosta nodded, arms folded. "We can't go unprepared Glimmer; we need weapons in case we run into space pirates or monsters or..."

“I'm sure Entrapta has that covered. Just… get into your seat and be ready for take-off." She turned away, touching her ear as she spoke into her comms, “Bow! You got Darla through the pre-flight systems check yet?"

Frosta sighed and headed towards Darla, dejected. She was tired of being ignored. As the youngest princess she had no-one her own age to play with and adults were boring. All they did was talk and kiss, yuck. At the top of the ramp she turned back to see Glimmer pacing up and down and talking rapidly into her microphone. The cockpit, where everyone would be waiting for her was to her left. Where Scorpia, Perfuma, Catra, Mermista and Sea Hawk would be waiting for her. Not to mention anyone else she had pranked with Double Trouble’s mimic crystal. There had been many.

She hesitated and turned in the opposite direction, towards the engine room. At least if she was on the ship she was doing as Glimmer had asked and she hadn't pranked Glimmer yet anyway. Plus there would only be two people in the engine room and she doubted Entrapta or Hordak would tell on her even if they knew about her misdemeanours. They were always far too busy to get involved in petty squabbles.

She reached the engine room and her heart lifted when she spotted Entrapta hovering on pigtails near the ceiling.

"Hi, Entrapta," she called out with a wave. She hopped onto a crate and giggled as Imp flew into her arms for a hug. The small creature cuddled into her as she petted his head.

"Hiiiiii, Frosta," Entrapta sang from above. The purple technician swung down to greet her new visitor. Her face was bright and alert but a shadow of concern crossed her eyes, "Is everything ok, Frosta? You don't normally visit the engine room."

Frosta squirmed but plastered a bright smile on her face, she'd assumed Entrapta wouldn't ask her anything, "I missed you!" she said on impulse. "Can I stay here for take-off?"

"Oh! Well that's nice. Yes, I guess so. You can use my seat and…"

A repetitive beep filled the air and the voice of Bow permeated the room,

"Cockpit to Engine room, Entrapta, are you there?"

"Hiii Bow" Entrapta answered, "we're just about ready for take-off. I just need to finish…." She typed into several screens at once, "Yep, that's us, ready to go!"

"Great! Thanks, Entrapta. By the way is Frosta down there? She's supposed to be in the cockpit with us."

"Yes! She is with me in the Engine Room, but don't worry Bow I can make sure she's safe until after the launch."

“Great,” Bow sounded relieved, perhaps he was trying to avoid a confrontation too, no doubt certain people were making complaints about her already. Frosta felt a pang of regret. Maybe leaving things as they were was a bad idea. Perfuma always said leaving things too long created resentment.

“As soon as Glimmer’s on board, we’re ready to go.” Bow finished speaking. Frosta hopped off the crate and headed towards the cockpit.

“Copy that.” Entrapta signed off and turned back to where Frosta had been sitting, “Okay, now… where’d she go?”

“I’d better go see Bow,” Frosta yelled back from the corridor, “I think I have some explaining to do.”

“Oh… Okay.” Entrapta sounded disappointed and Frosta felt sad but she had decided to say sorry and say sorry she would.

She made her way through the ship when she passed the landing bay doors again. They were still open. She was about to move on when a movement outside caught her attention. An old woman in pink seemed to be hovering behind a tree and staring at her. She beckoned to the ice princess and Frosta wondered what the old lady wanted. She still had time; they wouldn’t leave without Glimmer and Glimmer hadn’t boarded the ship yet.

Tentatively she made her way back down the gangplank and stood at the base of the ship. There it was, movement in the trees to her left. She walked to the tree but when she arrived, no-one was there.

“What?” she shook her head in disbelief and turned back towards Darla, ready to reboard and say sorry to her friends when the spaceship, gangplank now withdrawn and the hanger bay doors firmly closed, lifted up into the air. With a loud roar of engines and a whoosh of wind, Darla soared into the atmosphere and was gone.

Frosta stared after the ship in amazement. They had left without her. No princess left behind. That was their motto, and she'd been left behind.

A small smile spread across her face as she realised she no longer had to apologise or put up with adult kissy faces anymore. In fact, she was now the highest-ranking monarch on the whole planet. The world was hers, no rules she couldn't break, no place she couldn't go. The smile widened and she waggled her eyebrows,

"The princesses left me behind!"

Chapter 2: Oh frosticles!

Chapter Summary

> Frosta is excited about her new plans but first she'll have to keep Bright Moon's finest General from discovering the truth.

The smile grew on Frosta's face as her eyes gleamed and narrowed in anticipation.

"The princesses left me behind." She said taking care to enjoy every syllable. She waggled her eyebrows and breathed in… success. She was free for the first time to do whatever she liked anywhere on the planet. As the highest-ranking princess now left on Etheria, nothing was out of bounds and she couldn't wait to try out everything.

With a bounce in her step Frosta set off towards Bright Moon castle, just a few hundred meters from the launching site. She reached the main door where she was met by General Juliet and two guards.

"Good afternoon, Princess Frosta." Juliet's tone was brisk and businesslike. "You are not accompanying the princesses on their trip to Shireen?"

Frosta looked slightly guilty until she remembered she was a princess and fully capable of making her own decisions.

"There was a Change in Plans. I have decided to return home early due to... a Change in Plans. Queen Glimmer says I could stay here tonight."

Juliet looked at the small princess with an eyebrow raised but she stepped aside and allowed her to enter the main hall.

"As you wish, Princess Frosta. If you should require anything please do not hesitate to inform myself or the palace staff."

Frosta nodded in a haughty, practised manner. She walked, determined towards the staircase and the guest rooms but she could feel Juliet’s eyes watching her as she moved. She didn't dare turn around in case the palace guard became suspicious of her return to Bright Moon. She might contact Glimmer and then the jig would be up. The princesses might even come back for her.

She reached the top of the stairs and turned the corner. Only when she was quite out of sight did she run to her room and then slammed the door behind her. Then she realised she had already packed and all her belongings were on Darla hurtling towards deep space.

"Aw, frosticles!" She muttered. Her hands found their way into her pockets as she paced up and down the room and the hard lump of double troubles mimic stone fell into her palm. Her eyes lit up with a new idea. If Juliet thought Glimmer was ok with her being here, she wouldn't try to contact the real spaceship. There was a spare data pad in Bow’s workshop. He’d shown it to her a few times and she knew the passcode.

The workshop was just along the hall and it was the work of a few minutes to get in and grab it. She turned the camera off and dialled the number for Bright Moons security. When Juliet's face appeared on-screen, she seemed annoyed.

"General Juliet reporting. Who is this?"

Frosta brought the mimic crystal to her lips and said in Bows voice,

"Hey, General Juliet. It's Bow here. Sorry to disturb you but Glimmer asked me to call. It's Frosta. She's had to stay behind to return to her kingdom for... something, I don’t know what. Glimmer says it's ok if she stays at Bright Moon tonight so just let her stay and we'll see you when we get back. Frosta’s fine to do what she likes, play, eat ice cream, whatever... Just let her do whatever she wants, ‘kay?"

Juliet's face was a picture of stoic neutrality. Frosta wondered if the woman even had emotions. Seconds ticked by and she began to fear that the general had seen through her ruse and knew Frosta wasn't supposed to be in Bright Moon. Had she gone too far with the ice cream? Did Bow even talk like that? It had started out so well..."

Just as she was about to add something else to the conversation, Juliet spoke up with a smile.

"Of course, as you wish. Queen Glimmer is ever wise and a kind queen. I would enquire about whether your camera was malfunctioning however I see you are now out of range of planetary communications and it is a wonder you managed to send even a voice recording."

"Oh, uh, well," said Bow's voice, "yes, that is right. We are out of range so don't call back. We are fine, all good and kicking ass out here in space which is black and sparkly and good for spotting bad guys. We will be back soon, see ya!"

Frosta shut off the datapad before Juliet could respond and hoped any anomalies in Bow's voice would be put down to space hysteria. Anyway Juliet seemed to have bought it so she was free to engage in her very own party of one.

First, she pushed all the beds in the upper floors into the ballroom which was just along the corridor and jumped her way across the biggest trampoline park she'd ever seen. She tried crawling through the vents like she'd seen Entrapta do but she got stuck in a tight space and then fell out when a panel broke free, landing her on Glimmer's throne. She pretended to be her sparkly hero for a while ordering miscellaneous troops into battle or pretending to host Bright Moon's annual ball.

Frosta yawned. She needed a break from all the action. Back in her room she settled down to eat all the ice cream in the kitchens reasoning that if Mermista could do it then so could she. She was

just getting into chapter five of Mermysteries, The Tail of the Sunken Siren when there was a bang on the door.

“Princess Frosta,” Juliet was clearly annoyed about something, “I have just spoken with Queen Glimmer on Darla. She is not impressed one bit by your reckless behaviour. I insist you open this door at once and call her back.”

“Uh, oh…” Frosta staggered to her feet and looked around for an escape route. “What do I do?”

“Did somebody say Swift Wind?” the white horse flew in the window and landed beside the ice princess just as Juliet opened the door with the master key.

“No, but let’s go!” Frosta implored and she swung herself onto Swift Wind’s back.

“Wait,” Juliet said, “You need to…”

“I don’t need to do anything, I’m a princess.” She urged Swift Wind on and the great stallion reared up, blocking Juliet’s path.

“Uh, are you sure about this Frosta?” he asked, “General Juliet’s usually on the good guy’s side here.”

She shook her head, “Not today Swift Wind. Just get me out of here.”

He nodded (Adora always said to trust the princesses… didn’t she?) and swung towards the window again taking off into the blue sky while Juliet shouted demanding his return to the castle and for Frosta to see reason and apologise to Glimmer. Frosta heard none of it as she soared high in the sky atop the alicorn. The sights and sounds were breathtaking and the rush of wind in her hair felt refreshing. She laughed as Swift Wind made loop de loops and flew through clouds and he loved the way she giggled at his antics. Adora rarely wanted to fly so high or dive so fast but Frosta was like steel in her confidence of him. It made him want to fly forever.

The sky began to darken and Frosta's eyes were beginning to close.

"You want to go home?" he asked her gently.

"Hmm?" her eyes blinked open as she took in his words, "Oh, no! I want some fun before everyone gets back. I want to see the world."

"Oh…kay. So, where do you want to go?"

She pointed vaguely at the ground. "Down there somewhere."

"Where? Plumeria? But that's practically Glimmer's back yard. Surely you've been there before."

She sat up, awake now, "Actually, no. I've only seen the Whispering Woods, Elberon, Thaymor… I've never seen the other princess' kingdoms before. I had too much work to do back in the Kingdom of Snows."

Swift Wind made up his mind, "We have to fix this. To Plumeria!" He dived down into the Whispering Woods and landed in Plumeria to a growing crowd who were so excited to meet Frosta that she was inundated with offers of places to spend the night and parties to attend, she looked to Swift Wind for help.

"I know just the place," he said and he led her to Perfuma's guest hut where she cuddled into the softest blankets, Swift Wind by her side all night. It was perfect, nothing could go wrong.

In the darkness the mimic crystal began to glow. Frosta stirred in her sleep as voices came from it, repeating words from two miscreants talking quietly not far away.

Chapter 3: Enter, the Scary Bandits

Chapter Summary

> Frosta is really enjoying her time as the only Princess on Etheria until she discovers the Scary Bandits who, intent on stealing the planet's treasures from the princesses, give her something new to focus on. Tongue Lashor and Grizzlor may seem like run of the mill bad guys but Frosta will need to be on her toes to keep one step ahead.

Frosta's eyes flickered open. The mimic crystal in her pocket was glowing a pale blue. She pulled it out and heard words emanating from its glassy surface. Two voices, both male. She'd never heard these voices before but she recognised the names from various Princess Alliance meetings.

"Bad Guys," she whispered to herself, eyes wide. Double Trouble had told her the mimic crystal would warn her of danger. Perhaps this is what they had meant. A small smile grew as she listened in.

"Grrr, it's not fair. It should have been mine "

"It still can be Grizzlor, we just have to be patient."

"But I can't wait Tung Lashor! Hordak promised me the Fright Zone would be mine once he left to return to Horde Prime! Then he left and somehow the whole place goes to that dumb scorpion. I waited thirty-five years, working my ass off for nothing, grrr."

"Hey, it's not just you, you know. I owned the Crimson Wastes for like, five minutes. With Huntara gone I had it all, then that damn cat shows up and suddenly I'm sinking in quicksand before I can shout, 'Get outta here!' she even stole my whip. I had to buy a new one. I mean… buy one! I don't even carry cash. I just steal stuff I need and she made me steal money to buy a whip."
"It's not fair. Why do all the princesses have to own everything?"

Frosta heard the slap as Tung Lashor cuffed Grizzlor about the ear, "Because they're the princesses, dumb ass. They're rich."

There was a short pause as Frosta listened to the crystal. She could almost hear the cogs moving as each of the ruffians considered their predicament.

"Y'know Grizzlor… we should be doing more than just stealing trinkets. I heard there's real treasure in every kingdom in Etheria. With the princesses all off planet it should be easy pickings. Let's start here. Plumeria's rich right? I heard the greatest treasure is in the granary."

"Let's do it!"

Frosta heard the men move off and she quietly moved away from Swift Wind so as not to disturb the great horse. She picked up a lantern and left the tent, Swift Wind still sleeping peacefully. He was too loud for a stealth mission and besides, she could handle this one alone. She knew where the granary was, Swift Wind had pointed it out to her on their way past, and it had only one entrance.

She moved quickly around the tents, careful not to wake anyone, and found a hiding spot behind a dead tree trunk not far from the entrance to the tent. While the granary was in the centre of Plumeria, it was far enough away from the sleeping tents that no-one had awoken.

"They could at least guard their treasure," Frosta muttered to herself, "This place is so stupid."

The crystal began to glow pale blue again and the voices from the granary, which was another tent albeit a larger one under the branches of a great oak, gave Frosta all the information she needed.

"This is it!"

"What? It's just seeds Tung Lashor. This isn't treasure."

“Naw, Grizzlor, you gotta think big! These are all the seeds in Plumeria. We sell these and make a fortune!”

“What! I’m not selling some dumb seeds. That’s like goin’ straight. I might as well get a job.”

“We’re not just selling them, we’re selling stolen property.”

“Oh, right.”

Frosta had had enough, she raised the mimic crystal to her lips and projected her voice across the small clearing.

“Put the seeds back and come out slowly,” Perfuma’s voice said.

“Yeah, and we won’t hurt you,” Catra’s voice said for effect.

“But we might ‘ice’ you,” Frosta said in her own loud way.

There was panic in the granary,

“You said the princesses were gone!”

“They are gone, I mean…”

Frosta used her ice magic to create statues of several princesses outside the tent. Using her lantern she walked around the statues to create the effect of movement on the walls of the granary tent.

“They’re right outside! Tung Lashor we gotta go!”

“Ok, split up, we meet in Salineas tomorrow at one, go!”

Frosta watched in glee as the two men raced from the granary without a backwards glance. She let the ice sculptures melt away and then she entered the tent. The place was a mess, seeds everywhere, but the thugs had stashed most of them in a bag already. Frosta sighed. Perfuma would be furious when she found out but at least she’d stopped them from stealing the seeds. She was just about to leave the tent when she heard footsteps approaching. She suddenly felt afraid it was Tung Lashor or

Grizzlor returning for the seeds. She grabbed the bag without thinking and ran from the tent and into the woods as fast as she could.

Frosta ran until she couldn't run any further. The trees all looked the same out here in the forest. She stopped to get her breath back. No-one was following her but she couldn't remember the way back to Plumeria and Swift Wind.

"Don't panic," told herself, "It'll be fine."

"What will be fine?" said a voice behind her. She turned and screamed as a small woman in a pink baggy dress and shawl appeared.

"You! You're the woman I saw behind the tree when I was on Darla. It's your fault I got left behind!"

"Madame Razz's fault? Oh no, dearie I don't think so. I think you wanted to stay behind."

"I didn't want to… well… okay maybe it has been fun so far. But there's bad guys now, and I'm lost in the woods and someone was chasing me."

"Someone was chasing you? Ah, but Mara dearie… you don't look like Mara… anyway I saw you in the granary and came over to talk to you, to bake a pie, and you ran away."

"Wait, it was your footsteps I heard outside the granary tent?"

The old woman stared at Frosta unblinking through her enormous pink glasses. A faint smile on her lips made it seem as though she wasn't particularly interested in the conversation anymore.

"You want to bake a pie?" she asked with hope in her voice.

Frosta shook her head. "I want to go home," she said mournfully.

“Did somebody say Swift Wind?” the alicorn’s head appeared beside Frosta’s shoulder and she hugged him excitedly.

“Swift Wind! You found me. I thought I was lost.”

“Lost? You’re right next to our tent!” Frosta let go of Swift Wind and discovered he was right. They were standing next to their tent and Madame Razz had disappeared. It had to be magic. Someone was looking out for her and it was her job to look out for Etheria.

“Swift Wind, we have to get to Salineas by one o’clock. And get us a boat!”

*****

“This is boring.” Frosta sat on the deck of the boat her legs swinging over the side. They’d managed to hire a small boat to take them to Salineas and now the entire fleet had been summoned to defend the Sea Gate but so far, after hours of waiting, no-one had turned up to attack. Swift Wind trotted over.

“Battles aren’t always exciting Frosta. We’re not even sure they’ll actually show up!”

Frosta sighed. This wasn’t the way she’d imagined an epic sea battle.

“I’m going for a walk.” She jumped from the deck into the ocean, turning the water into ice as she did so, so she landed on an ice pack. Dejected she turned to walk towards the Sea Gate and the Sea Pearl. It wasn’t fair. Why couldn’t she have just one epic battle on the high seas to brag about when the other princesses returned home?

As she walked, the water before her becoming ice beneath her feet, she noticed a small boat tied up next to the Sea Gate almost hidden beneath it. She remembered the book she’d read in Bright

Moon, Mermysteries The Tail of the Sunken Siren. Of course! Tongue Lashor and Grizzlor had no backup! How could they possibly fight the whole of Salineas' army with only the two of them? Instead they were sneaking in the back way to… well, whatever they were after it wasn't good.

Frosta crept up to the boat and found an open door leading inside Salineas. Evidently the pair had found themselves an unguarded entrance and broken a lock to gain entry. Frosta could hear them just inside.

"Hey Tongue Lashor, this'll be easy right?"

"Yeah, those stupid Salineans have the whole army outside, there's no-one left to guard the pearls."

"Stupid Salineans."

"You know Grizzlor, you're not so sharp yourself."

"What does that mean?"

"It means, if you try any of that drawing scary faces on the walls like you did in Plumeria and Thaymor, I'm going to get mad again."

"But we're the Scary Bandits. We gotta leave our calling card Tongue Lashor, or else how will anyone know it was us?"

"Geez, how'd I end up with you, idiot. Look, there's the pearls. Just grab them and go."

Frosta, listening outside, drew the mimic crystal out of her pocket and summoned the voice of the Sea Princess.

"Gruhh, this is so boring. I'm coming down now, into the basement there. Yeah, I'm gonna need whoever's in there to just… leave. Right now."

Tung Lashor and Grizzlor stared at each other in horror.

“Mermista’s on Etheria too? I thought they all left?”

“They did. I know they did. I watched them go.”

“First Perfuma and now Mermista? Something fishy is going on here and I’m gonna find out what.”

Tongue Lashor raised his voice, “Princess Mermista? We’re security. We were sent down to check on the Sea Pearls. Everything’s ok down here.”

There was a short pause.

“Oh, uuuh great. That’s great.”

“Do you still want to come down here and check on us?”

Frosta hesitated. She’d expected them to leave in a hurry, without the pearls, and rush off in their boat. Having Mermista appear in the room was not part of her plan.

“Uuh, that’s ok. Back to your job, sea-rats!”

Was that how Mermista talked? Frosta shrugged and figured, probably it was. She was always rather blunt with people, especially servants.

Inside, Tongue Lashor winked at Grizzlor who stifled a snigger.

“Very well your majesty,” he said. “We’ll just get back to our jobs guarding the Sea Gate.”

“You do that!” said Mermista’s voice. The sound of footsteps echoed around the room and then a door opened and closed. Silence followed. Frosta was tempted to peek around the doorway but something didn’t feel right. She held herself tall and walked into the room with a confident air, the mimic crystal tight in her hand.

“Sea Hawk, can you come in here and help me with the… crates? Mermista said to take them to the shore for the storage lockers,” she turned back towards the door she had entered by and lifted her hand to her mouth, the crystal hidden in her palm.

“I’ll be there in a minute,” Sea Hawk’s voice called back from seemingly outside.

Frosta causally wondered around the room as if bored, waiting for Sea Hawk to arrive. She walked around a crate and found Grizzlor and Tongue Lashor crouched behind it.

“Hey, who are you?” she asked, eyes narrowed. Let’s see them explain themselves now.

The pair flinched in fright and Grizzlor dropped the bag of pearls he was holding. Frosta picked them up and raised her eyebrows in a question.

“We’re guards,” Tongue Lashor said, standing up, “Guarding the Sea Pearls.”

“Yeah,” Grizzlor added, standing next to him, “Guards.”

“Oh, so you’re not thieves stealing from the princesses?” Frosta glared at them and an ice axe formed along her arm.

“You know about that!” Grizzlor exclaimed, “I mean we lost the Plumeria Seeds and I only grabbed the Brightmoon Light Lantern a few hours ago.”

“Shut up!” Tongue Lashor said, nudging him in the ribs.

“The Light Lantern. Hand it over!” she raised the ice axe high above her head. Grizzlor sighed and handed over the item.

“Where are all the other princesses?” asked Tongue Lashor, curious. “I thought they all left but they were in Plumeria and now here… wait… the princesses did leave didn’t they? You’re the only one here!”

Frosta shook her head, “No, they didn’t go. You just heard Mermista and Sea Hawk two minutes ago.”

“Ah, but we didn’t see them. Ok I’ll bite. You shout for a princess, any princess and if they appear I’ll believe you. Otherwise, I think they left you behind. I think you’re here on Etheria all alone.”

Frosta hesitated. She wasn’t afraid of them but what should she do? She couldn’t let them steal from her friends. With a blast of ice she tried to secure them both to the floor but they were surprisingly fast. Years of fighting for survival in the Horde and the Crimson Waste had given both men the ability to spot a threat and dive out of the way easily.

“I won’t let you steal the planet’s treasures,” she called out as the pair fled for the exit.

Tongue Lashor’s reply was short, “We’ll get you for this Princess Frosta! Horde Prime will look like a picnic compared to what I’ll do if you get in our way.”

“Yeah,” Grizzlor added from the doorway, “you better not go to Dryl, coz that’s where we’ll be heading next!”

“You stupid dolt, don’t tell her where we’re headed!”

Frosta smiled to herself. This war was on and she was ready to fight.

Chapter 4: Take what we can

Chapter Summary

The Scary Bandits have found their way to Dryl.

_____

Grizzlor and Tongue Lasher stood in front of the main door. It was locked.
"Now what?" Grizzlor queried.
Tongue Lashor growled. "We find a window, anything. We have to get inside."
"What are we here for again? There's no treasure in Dryl, just robots. Even Hordak refused to attack this remote region until Entrapta just handed it over to us. Even then it was just for show."
"Just for show? Grizzlor, you really are the dumbest of them all."
"What! Why?"
Tongue Lashor shook his head and rolled his eyes. "Never mind. Just help me break this lock."

Frosta and Swift Wind arrived in Dryl long before the Scary Bandits whose transport was far slower than the winged stallion. Swift Wind touched down in the courtyard but he wouldn't stay.

"Sorry Frosta, it's just waay too creepy here. I'll wait outside for you though. If you need anything just shout 'SWIFT WIND!' and I'll come running… or trotting even."

She smiled at him and punched the air for effect, "Don't worry Swift Wind, I've got this." With a defiant air she marched towards Crypto Castle's main entrance. The tall, wooden doorway loomed large before her. She wondered why Entrapta needed such a large, dramatic and imposing entranceway to a fortress which was difficult to get to by foot never mind hauling vehicles, supplies and infantry to. How did you even begin to try and conquer such a

remote and mountainous region? She couldn't work out why Entrapta had isolated herself quite so profusely using traps and mazes when her castle was already highly defended by the mountain and, in any effect, mostly underground.

She pushed open the large wooden door and stepped through. For such an impregnable fortress it seemed odd that the door wasn't even locked. But then Entrapta was, for the most part, an enigma to Frosta. Carefully, so as not to disturb anything, she turned to the nearest wall and found a square, wooden box secured there. She placed her palm on the sensor in the middle of the box. A light scanned her hand, a bleep, the surface flashed green and the door to the box opened revealing a datapad.

"Yes!" Frosta said then reached for the datapad and commenced switching it on. Entrapta had installed the device to allow any princess emergency access to her castle and all its secrets. It was the ultimate show of trust and Frosta knew how important trust was. After all, didn't she have to learn to trust the princesses after Princess Prom?

She switched on the datapad and Entrapta's emoji icon lit up the screen. Then a systems list appeared and Frosta clicked on the first one. A loud thud echoed around the entranceway as the front door slammed shut and bolts slid into place. Ah, so the door could be secured. Frosta smiled to herself. This was going to be fun.

*****

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"Now what?" Grizzlor queried.

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“What are we here for again? There’s no treasure in Dryl, just robots. Even Hordak refused to attack this remote region until Entrapta just handed it over to us. Even then it was just for show.”

“Just for show? Grizzlor, you really are the dumbest of them all.”

“What! Why?”

Tongue Lashor shook his head and rolled his eyes. “Never mind. Just help me break this lock.”

The pair worked together to unpick the lock until a satisfying click meant the deadbolt had reversed. The massive bolts holding the huge door closed disengaged, allowing the door to swing ajar. With a smug smile Tongue Lashor pushed it open and stepped inside.

The dark entranceway was eerily quiet and still. Several corridors led in different directions to unknown destinations. Grizzlor stood next to his companion,

“What now?”

“Don’t whisper.”

“WHAT NOW?”

“Ahh!! Don’t shout, you made me jump and drop the key.”

“What key?”

“Would you stop asking questions? This key.” Tung Lashor held up the large wrought iron key and Grizzlor studied it.

“What’s it for?”

“Would you stop…!” Tung Lashor took a deep breath and smoothed back his hair in one hand. “This is the key to the throne room where Entrapta keeps the Dryl scrolls.

“The what now?”

In another part of the castle, Frosta waited, listening into the conversation via the mimic crystal. In her other hand she typed into the datapad to find the throne room.

“Aha, gottcha!” she said, a smug tone to her voice.

The throne room was directly beneath Entrapta’s lab and used a large set of stairs to guide a visitor to the entranceway.

“I got this key from a robot in the Crimson Waste,” Tongue Lashor continued, “It came from Dryl. The robot said it was the only way to get into the throne room.”

Frosta’s eyebrows scrunched together. That didn’t make any sense. That robot had gone amiss in the Crimson Wastes back when Mara’s ship was still stranded. She knew this because Entrapta had given the princesses an incredibly boring lecture on its various rambling adventures with a slide show and dictated voice recordings for complete, authentic immersion experience. She sighed. There certainly hadn’t been any mention of the robot carrying the one and only key to Dryl’s treasure; ancient scrolls depicting life on Etheria traversing millennia, irreplaceable and invaluable to the whole planet…

Also she’d been inside the throne room. It wasn’t amazing in her opinion, nothing like her own throne back home. Evidently there was at least one more key and Entrapta had never mentioned any precious scrolls if they even existed. She certainly hadn’t seen any.

It didn’t matter. The ‘bad guys’ were here and she was here to stop them.

“I HAVE THE POWER!”

The voice echoed from the mimic stone along the corridors to arrive at the main entrance in a booming crescendo that took time to die out as each of the men stood stock still in horror.

“Was that…?”

“She-Ra?”

“She’s never said that before…”

“Well she should!” Frosta’s voice broke out along the empty corridors and she gasped at her mistake. She hadn’t meant to use her own voice so they could hear her. As a quick recovery she drew the mimic stone to her lips and tried again. This time as Entrapta.

“Ahahaha! Welcome to Dryl. If you’ll just follow my robots, I’ll meet you downstairs in a jiffy. I just have to… ah… ummm… wash my hair!”

Frosta stuffed the mimic crystal in her pocket and groaned. Why was she messing this up? If Grizzlor and Tongue Lashor even believed the princesses were still on Etheria they were even dumber than she’d thought. She pulled the datapad closer and tracked them down the hall. Strangely enough they were moving in the direction of the throne room. Perhaps she could trap them after all and be the hero when everyone got back. Frosta smiled and said to herself,

“Winter’s Bane, the white knight of Etheria at your service!”

*****

Grizzlor nudged Tongue Lashor as every corridor lit up with red lights. Some of them blinked. Strange sounds of whirring, grinding and clicking emanated from the newly emerging silhouettes inside.

“What’s going on?” he asked, “Was that really, She-Ra? We should leave!”

Tongue Lashor tapped his nose, “I’m getting a whiff of something strange here, Grizzlor. Don’t you notice?”

“Notice what? All the princesses are still here? We’re gonna get caught.”

“Nah, the princesses ain’t here. It’s just Frosta. Don’t you see? She’s the only one we’ve actually seen since they left. We saw the ship leave the planet and they were on it. They left Frosta behind.”

“Ohhh… so what do we do?”

“We play along. Do what she wants, and then bam! We grab her, get her to give us the treasures of the Kingdom of Snows, and all the other ones she stole from us, and then run off to the Fright Zone. We just gotta keep it cool. We’re in Dryl, remember. The hardest place in Etheria to navigate. She doesn’t stand a chance against us.”

“Yeah, kids are afraid of getting lost.”

“You’re afraid of getting lost too Grizzlor. Remember that time I lost you in Thaymor? You were close to tears when I found you in that bin, hiding.”

“Oh, yeah… that.”

The robots emerged with smiling, blushing faces and open arms. The pair stepped forwards to follow them along a corridor towards a wide set of steps leading downwards.

“Uh… Tongue Lashor. Is this a good idea? This place is full of traps.”

“Don’t worry I have the master key.” He dangled another key and from several rooms away Frosta watched, entranced. “This key opens every door in the castle.”

“Oh, that’s good.”

Frosta sniggered, careful not to let her voice carry to the mimic crystal. Those idiots thought they had control… well she would show them.

The robots led the way down the stairs to the throne room and Tongue Lashor pushed his key into the lock. It turned halfway and stuck.

“Hey, why won’t it open. It’s the right…”

The door clicked and opened automatically as Frosta released the mechanism on her datapad. Tongue Lashor sighed in relief and pushed the door wide with a theatrical air.

“Did you ever doubt me?”

Grizzlor grinned and strode past him into the throne room.

“You had me going there with the key not turning, Tongue Lashor. But I’ll say this, you came through all right.”

They entered the room, the throne itself at the far end, a mighty stone edifice carved of sparkling granite and quartz crystals. Behind it the stone walls were alight with mosaics of ancient deities and depictions of monarchs long since deceased. It was beautiful.

Grizzlor was not impressed.

“Where are the scrolls, Tongue Lashor? You said they’d be here.”

“They’re here somewh… ahh!”

The pair stepped further into the room, and onto a stone paving block. When their weight pressed against the stone it shifted to the side and they fell, head-long into a tunnel pulling them deeper underground and away from the treasures they sought.

They landed in a heap on a sodden floor, darkness enveloping them completely until a single lamp was lit. Frosta stood on the other side of the bars, the cell they were now trapped in cold and wet.

“Hi guys,” she said with a smile and an eyebrow waggle. “Bet you wanna find those scrolls, right? Just so you know, I’ve been listening to every word you’ve said since you got here. So why don’t you try that key, see if it works.”

Tongue Lashor stood up in a fury,

“Give us the scrolls now puny princess or you’ll rue the day you got in our way!”

Frosta laughed, her eyes narrowed.

“Just try me!”

With a snarl Tongue Lashor drew out his master key and turned it in the lock. Frosta waited, certain that nothing would happen but when the key turned and the lock fell away, the cell door opening with the ease of a well-oiled gate, her face fell into a look of shock.

“Well, well Princess Frosta. Looks like the tables have turned.” He reached to grab for the small princess but she dodged and skipped up the stairs to the next level.

“If you want the scrolls and all the other treasures, you better come find me!”

She ran off, the datapad showing her both the directions she needed and the locations of every trap in the castle. Tongue Lashor and Grizzlor chased after her, determined to catch her.

Without taking her eyes off the datapad she ran down a corridor stepping only on particular stones. The Scary Bandits chased after, their larger feet stomping over everything and causing the walls to erupt in arrows, saws and flying knives in turn. Screaming, they dodged the projectiles, narrowly missing several and only being hit by a few arrows which they pulled out and discarded.

Undeterred, Frosta ran for the kitchens. The staff had taken the week off so they were empty. Frosta quickly turned on the gas

rings of the cooker, opened the vat of cooking oil and tipped over the barrel, stood in the doorway opposite the side she'd entered from… and lit a long tapir.

The Scary Bandits skidded into the kitchens, sliding on the oil so their legs flew up into the air. There was a comical moment when both men were running backwards on the spot as they tried not to fall until, finally, with a cry of alarm, they lost their balance. Legs flew into the air and they landed on their backs in a painful connection with the concrete floor.

With groans and painful mutterings they sat up and focussed bleary eyes upon Frosta who stood, the lit tapir flickering, and smiled.

"Don't get up," she said, "I'll see myself out."

The Scary Bandits watched in horror as the small princess threw the flame into the gas-filled room and dived out of the way. With a huge boom, the gas exploded in a single burst of fire. They sat there, stunned, blackened with soot, clothes ragged and patchy as their senses returned.

"I'm gonna get her!" Tongue Lashor yelled.

He stood up and raced out of the door to be met with an icy floor. He skidded, arms flailing, legs haphazard and unable to stop and was met with a concoction of ramps, twisting hallways, secret doorways and tiny spaces he barely made it through. He twisted and rolled, grabbing at anything he could, to try to stop, but in the end, it was a dead end in the passageway that he smacked right into. Moments later Grizzlor crashed into his back, sandwiching him between a brick wall and a fuzzy former Horde Force Captain.

The Scary Bandits fell backwards onto the ice, their heads hitting the icy floor in a wave of pain and nausea.

"Uhm, Tongue Lashor," Grizzlor groaned, "Can we get out of here? I just want to go home."

Tongue Lashor looked at him, his head spinning, "You look like someone I know." He paused, shook his head and then stood up carefully, helping Grizzlor up and onto a nearby, ice free staircase.

"That's it, no more Mr Nice Guy," he said, venom dripping from his words. "You hear that kid? We're coming to get you!"

"Yeah, we're done playing games."

Frosta's head poked around the top of the stairs.

"Oh, yeah? You'd better come get me then!"

Her head disappeared and they raced up the stairs after her to find themselves back in the main entrance. Frosta stood in the open doorway, the datapad in her hand. A dark shadowy figure stood next to her, a silhouette against the bright light of day. She reached out her arm to hand something over, a couple of bags and a lantern…

"Hey, those are ours!" Tongue Lashor cried out.

"Why, thank you, Princess Frosta." The lazy drawl of Double Trouble was unmistakeable. They tossed their head and a golden mane shivered back into place along their back.

"Give them back," Grizzlor roared, "We need the money to fund the Fright Zone after we steal it tomorrow."

"Hey," Tongue Lashor slapped the back of Grizzlor's head, "Don't tell her that. She doesn't need to know what we're planning."

"Oh, it's ok. I already know." Frosta sent a beam of ice in their direction but once more the pair dodged out of the way. The ice-covered floor sparkled.

The dark outline of Double Trouble disappeared as they left, taking the treasures with them. Frosta barred the doorway, legs akimbo and arms ready to defend herself.

“Look, you don’t need this,” Tongue Lashor said jovially, “Just give us the treasures and we’ll be on our way. We’ll even stay out of your kingdom as a good will gesture.”

Frosta glared at him. “This is how it’s going to work. I’m going to give you both one more chance. Just because you haven’t actually managed to steal anything yet. I’ll give you to the count of ten to get out of Dryl and leave everyone alone forever more, or I’ll fill your lungs full of icicles, you got it?”

She stepped back into the Dryl courtyard outside and began counting backwards from ten.

Tongue Lashor and Grizzlor stared at each other with questioning expressions. In the same moment they realised the same thing and ran for the exit, sliding and falling over the icy floor. They reached the courtyard at the count of five and ran headlong past the ice princess towards the mountain pass and away. As they passed the outer walls of the fortress Frosta sent a hail of ice towards the thieves so they were bombarded with tiny frozen bullets as they ran.

Frosta laughed. “Well done Swift Wind. You did a great impression of Double Trouble.”

“My pleasure. I especially love the head toss. Very authentic don’t you think?”

They laughed. The mimic crystal lit up again and the voices of the Scary Bandits filtered through.

“Are we really giving up, Tongue Lashor?”

“Of course not. We just had to get rid of the brat. Now she won’t bother us we can head to the Fright Zone and get organised. Our friends from the Crimson Wastes and the Horde will arrive tomorrow evening. We just have to have everything ready.”

“What about the treasures? We need the money to pay the troops.”

“We’ll steal it back later, there’s plenty of time Grizzlor.”

The mimic crystal blinked off and Frosta and Swift Wind shared a look of determination.

“We have to get there first!”

“Hop on, I’ll get us there in no time.”

Chapter 5: Winter's Bane meets the Fright Zone

Chapter Summary

> Tongue Lashor and Grizzlor arrive in the Fright Zone but discover, to their dismay, that Frosta arrived first.

> The lizard man peered over the beast man’s shoulder, squinting at the handwritten note.
> “Don’t look up? What does that mean?” The two men looked up in interest, trying to see into the beams of the vast roof system which was packed with pipes of all shapes and sizes.
> “I don’t see anything.”
> A small, continuous noise began to sound and the pair looked at each other in mild confusion. Then a large sandbag dropped onto Tongue Lashor’s head, knocking him to the ground in one sudden movement.
> “Oh, it was a sandbag.” Grizzlor smiled, pleased that he finally understood the message.

Frosta knew she was limited on time. There was maybe only an hour left until the Scary Bandits would show up on their skiff, which was far slower than Swift Wind. The winged stallion had dropped her off and helped her set up as many traps as they could but now it was time for him to take a step back. Frosta needed him to be waiting for her at the rendezvous point. If all went to plan, they could trap the thieves, alert the Brightmoon guards and be gone without a trace before Juliet even knew she had been in the Fright Zone. Frosta still wanted to have some fun on Etheria on her own terms.

She laid the last piece of the plan down on the ground in the middle of the loading bay and ran off to hide. If all went to plan this would be the best battle scene ever.

*****

Grizzlor and Tongue Lashor landed the skiff in the middle of the loading bay. They shut down the engine and stepped off. Grizzlor noticed the letter laying on the ground in the middle of the loading bay and picked it up.

"Hey, Tongue Lashor. What's this?"

The lizard man peered over the beast man's shoulder, squinting at the handwritten note.

"Don't look up? What does that mean?" The two men looked up in interest, trying to see into the beams of the vast roof system which was packed with pipes of all shapes and sizes.

"I don't see anything."

A small, continuous noise began to sound and the pair looked at each other in mild confusion. Then a large sandbag dropped onto Tongue Lashor's head, knocking him to the ground in one sudden movement.

"Oh, it was a sandbag." Grizzlor smiled, pleased that he finally understood the message.

Tongue Lashor was less pleased.

"Hey, there's a second note," Grizzlor picked up another note attached to the sandbag.

"What's it say?" Tongue Lashor staggered to his feet and listened as Grizzlor read it aloud.

"Dear Dopes,
You came to the Fright Zone so be prepared to be flattened. I'll either be in Horror Hall or in Hordak's old throne room. Come and get me if you dare!
Frosta."

"Gimme that!" Tongue Lashor snatched the paper from his partner and scanned the words again. Grizzlor paced up and down.

Tongue Lashor made a decision but he didn't like it.

"We have to split up!"

*****

Grizzlor paced backwards and forwards at the base of Hordak's old throne. He felt nervous in this room without the old warlord present. He'd only ever been in here to report back on some tactic or other which, mostly, had failed in some way. Now he came to think about it Hordak had almost always ended his speeches with, "This is the last time I will stand for this Grizzlor! One more mistake and it's off to Beast Island with you."

He smiled to himself, ah, good times, good times. Without thinking he had been making his way up the staircase to the throne itself and now he sat down with a flourish pretending to be Lord Hordak, ruler of the Fright Zone. He glared at the imaginary soldiers beneath him and growled.

"You!" he pointed at the offending Force Captain who wasn't there, "Get me a hot chocolate and be quick about it! And you… I hate you, go to Beast Island immediately and don't come back!"

He laughed at his own jokes and leaned back into the large throne. It was really too large for him even with his fur puffed out. There was a small button in the armrest. Curious he pressed it and the chair began to vibrate into a relaxing massage. It reclined back and he closed his eyes with a hum of contentment. It had been a rough war and hiding from everyone for the past few months had been exhausting. He deserved a short break. Just as he was drifting off to sleep, he heard a small noise from above. Opening his eyes he saw a panel in the vents above open and a small head peeked out.

Frosta waved at him. He growled back. He opened his mouth to speak just as she waved a red balloon right above his head and he stared at it in confusion. What in Etheria…

She dropped the water balloon right onto Grizzlor's head where it immediately burst. The water hit the electronics panel and short circuited the chair. Grizzlor screamed as the chair electrocuted him and he leaned back in surprise. The chair, now tipped too far back, broke at the base and slid down the back steps behind the throne. Grizzlor held on tight as the chair careened backwards, bumping down every stair as it went. At the bottom the chair hit the floor with enough force to break the chair in half and throw Grizzlor high into the air. He landed in a huge barrel of tar where his fur became heavy and thick so he couldn't move. Looking back up at the ceiling he could see Frosta's small face leaning down from the vents. She laughed and pointed at him.

"Got you!" she chanted, "See ya!" she disappeared into the vent and Grizzlor howled in anger as he was left once more alone.

*****

Tongue Lashor paced angrily in front of the old Scorpion throne. Why did Frosta have to be here? Why hadn't she given up? Bored, he sat down on the throne and felt something spiky under him. He jumped up in surprise to find the old Scorpion crown and sceptre just sitting there. With a smile he picked up the old crown and set it on his head then picked up the sceptre. Turning to the empty void of Horror Hall he addressed his imaginary subjects.

"Welcome, welcome all. You may be wondering why I've asked you here today. Well, I have just realised I have been your King for many years now but I have forgotten the coronation. Haha, silly me. So today, I will be coronated as King of the Fright Zone."

He bowed to the imaginary cheers and well wishes from his admirers then sat back down on the throne. He hummed the fanfare and made-up lines for his big moment and was just getting to the good bit when he spotted Frosta by the main door.

“Hey! You, come here!” he let go of the sceptre to go catch the small princess but it was stuck to his hand. No matter what he did he couldn’t shake it off. He tried to pull it with his other hand but it became glued on too. The crown was glued to his head so tight it didn’t even wobble. He glared at Frosta and she grinned back.

“Guess someone was careless with the glue,” she with concern in her voice, it became mischievous, “Bet you can’t catch me!”

Tung Lashor ran towards her just as she used her magic to cover the floor in ice and he screamed as he slid the full length of the hall into the wall beside Frosta. She tutted.

“Oh, dear. Guess someone forgot to defrost Horror Hall too! Guess the Fright Zone just became the Frost Zone!”

She giggled as she left the room and Tung Lashor fell backwards onto the floor with a groan. He tried to pull himself back up but the icy floor and the sceptre stuck to his hands made things difficult. He managed to drag himself to the doorway and stood up as soon as he was free of the ice. Frosta waved to him from a little way along the corridor.

“I’m right over here,” she sang, “Bet you can’t catch me.”

With a growl Tung Lashor raced after her only to slide on the pearls Frosta had left scattered across the floor and landed on his back once more. His head and tail ached with pain where he’d landed on them twice. With a last glance at the many blue princesses running away, he felt his world black out and his eyes close.

*****

The barrel lay on its side on the grimy floor, tar oozing out of it in thick, globules. Grizzlor dragged his body away from the mess by his arms which were covered in it. His fur was so thick with sludge it doubled its weight. He pulled himself to his feet and reached out for a handy towel hanging on the wall at the back of the

room. He wiped his face and arms before sniffing the air, curious. There was a rancid, sharp smell.

He glanced down at the towel and gasped. It wasn't a towel he found there but Hordak's old cape he'd worn before Princess Entrapta had designed him new armour. It stank of… turpentine... diesel… no kerosine. He nodded in recognition of the smell, then his eyes grew wide in horror. Why would it smell of kerosine? He pulled the offending article of clothing from his arm, ripping a patch of fur away with it where the tar had stuck to the cloth.

He howled in pain, dropping the cape on the floor and waving his arm around in an attempt to dampen the reddened sting. He dared not touch the bald patch with his hands still covered in tar and kerosine and there was no sink to clean it off.

He strode towards the door, determined to find Tongue Lashor and a shower. This was no way to spend his first day as ruler of the Fright Zone. As he walked, the cape stuck to his padded foot and was dragged along behind him. With a groan of frustration he tried to pull it off by standing on it with his other foot but he only succeeded in both feet becoming stuck to the fabric. A large rip tore through the middle of the cape where he'd tried to remove it and it was now saturated in kerosine and tar. Just as well Hordak didn't wear it anymore. It certainly couldn't be worn now.

Despite the tear, both feet were now secured, close together, to the cloth of the cape like a mat. He reached the doorway and strode through with tiny movements using all of his concentration. He suddenly realised he was in Hordak's sanctum and not the corridor he'd been aiming for. He must have taken the wrong door. He shuffled between the vitrines to reach the main door to the corridor, expecting it to open automatically.

The door wouldn't open. Instead of the touchpad, a pull-cord hung from the wall. He stared at it. This was odd. Everything in the Fright Zone was automated. Especially in here. Whoever heard of a pull-cord to open a door?

With no other options available Grizzlor reached out to pull the cord. Nothing happened. There was a peculiar smell of burning fur. He sniffed the air tentatively and turned around. In the reflection of a green glass vitrine he saw his face… and a ring of fire burning his hair in a column a foot tall. Evidently the pull-cord had been attached to a flame thrower.

He screamed and looked around desperately for water. A sink was positioned against the wall and he ran to it but no matter how much he turned the taps, no water fell from them. In a panic he ran across the room searching for any kind of liquid to quench the flames which were now covering half of his fuel soaked back and arms. Desperate, he launched himself into the air and dived into the nearest vitrine of green goo where he sighed in relief. At least the fire was out.

*****

Tongue Lashor woke up on the pearl-covered floor and felt his eyes water. Where was he? It came back to him slowly as he gathered his wits and stood up gingerly. The pearls from Salineas were everywhere, impossible to collect without taking hours to find them all. That Frosta!

Tongue Lashor snarled and tried once more to pull his hands from the sceptre, to no avail. Another treasure destroyed by that infernal child. He'd have to destroy both sceptre and crown just to remove them from his body, the glue was so strong.

He headed along the corridor he'd last watched her run down and found himself near the canteen. The room inside was large and full of tables and chairs, the perfect place for an ambush. He tested the door with an elbow to make it move a little. Nothing happened. Maybe she hadn't come this way, but a wet shoeprint just under the door told a different story.

He pushed the door open a little more and when, again, nothing happened he strode through ready to confront the little wretch when a bucket fell on his head and shoulders, covering him in sugary, sweet, sticky syrup. He yowled and thrashed until the bucket fell off but he didn't look where he was going and didn't see the string across the doorway that pulled the switch for the fan.

As the bucket dropped to the floor, the fan blew Plumerian seeds across the room to hit his body with the force of a tornado covering him in the assortment of tiny spheres, oblongs and ovals from top to toe.

The fan stopped. He spat out a mouthful of seeds and took a moment of reflection before lashing out on the furniture. He thrust the sceptre into a table so many times that it broke in the middle. Feeling slightly better he stood back up and straightened his now ruined jacket and trousers as best as he could. The gold sceptre was bent in the middle, the crown was glued as tight as ever, his body was covered in syrup and seeds and he felt as though he had been hit by a sledgehammer… and the floor was covered in glass.

Tongue Lashor didn't wear shoes but he wasn't about to let the little princess get the better of him. He carefully he made his way across the room towards the kitchen stifling cries of pain as he moved. He pushed the door, a little more carefully this time until it was open as wide as possible. Nothing happened.

"Ok, kid. Come out here. I won't hurt you. I just wanna be friends."

There was a shuffle inside and then silence.

"You in there kid? Look I'm sorry, we got off to a bad start. Just… come on out and I'll make it up to you."

"You promise?" the voice was further away than Tongue Lashor had expected.

“I promise,” he replied with feeling. Kids were so gullible, they’d believe anything. He grinned to himself. He’d show her what happened to anyone who messed with him.

“Ok, I’ll come out then.”

Tongue Lashor grinned. This was easy. He should have just asked her in the first place. He stood up as he saw her emerge from behind a fridge on the far side of the kitchen. He smiled wide to show sincerity and was just about to open his mouth when she smiled back… and pulled a leaver.

A hatch opened above his head and a wasp’s nest dropped out. The nest burst on the floor and the angry insects launched at him. Covered as he was in sugary treats, they landed on him to sting, bite, eat the syrup and generally overwhelm him. Screaming he ran around the room with the swarm chasing him back and forth across the door. The glass covered floor was agony to traverse but the wasps were relentless.

Frosta laughed. It was too easy to mess with these guys and keep them busy. Tongue Lashor ran as fast as he could around the canteen furniture, on the sharp spikes of glass, until he could run into the kitchen. He slammed the door shut behind him. Only a few wasps had followed him inside but his face was blotched and puffy from the stings anyway so he didn’t care. He swatted them away and turned to Frosta, furious.

“You wanna tell me what this is all about?”

She grew serious, hands on hips, “Don’t steal from me or my friends. You don’t want to know what comes next.”

Tongue Lashor laughed, “Is that it? I’m coming after you kid and when I get you…”

He lunged forward and Frosta leapt back with a large grin, “Gotta catch me first, big guy.”

With a roar he ran after her but she was too fast and had reached the opposite door before he reached the centre of the room. She held up a lantern and Tongue Lashor stopped short when he suddenly realised what it was.

"Hey, kid. Can you just put that down gently? That's the Brightmoon Lantern of Light and it's worth a fortune."

He pleaded with her with his eyes and when she gently tossed the lantern in the air to catch it without looking, he knelt down on the floor, arms out in front still attached to the sceptre, and begged her not to destroy it.

"Oh come on kid. Gimme a break, I just need it to sell for dosh to run this place. Grizzlor and I have to pay the troops when they arrive so they stay and we can be Emperors of the Fright Zone. Hey, I'll cut you a deal. You give me the lantern and I'll make you a Duchess of Darkness. I'll even throw in a crown and… and… your own throne for when you visit."

Frosta looked at him, consideration in her eyes. "That does sound tempting… but I have my own kingdom and it already comes with a crown and a throne so… no, no deal"

She tossed the Lantern of Light at Tongue Lashor who reached out to grab it. It landed at his feet, breaking into shards of opulent glass and golden latticework. Too late Tongue Lashor realised his mistake as the air smelled faintly of gas which ignited instantly on the impact of the lantern. The whole kitchen blew up as Frosta dived out of the way. She had deliberately left the gas rings on, filling the room with the noxious substance. The flames suffused the whole kitchen, lighting it up with impossible brilliance, only to diffuse just as quickly. In the centre of the space, blackened by ash and grime, Tongue Lashor opened his mouth and puffed out a ring of black smoke.

The immense heat had melted the soft metal of the golden sceptre and Tongue Lashor stared at his empty hands, the Plumerian Seeds burnt to a crisp alongside some errant Salinean

Pearls, the Lantern of Light destroyed before him. He wept. He cried tears of rage and earnest pain and then stood up once more to yell at the small princess who had caused all of this destruction.

"FROSTA! I'm gonna get you. You better run, you little pipsqueak!"

She sniggered from along the corridor and he heard her feet run off. He chased her.

*****

Grizzlor pulled himself up to the edge of the vitrine gasping for air. He'd forgotten he couldn't swim he'd been so intent on getting the flames out. His fur was singed, burnt, ripped off and now covered in green goo and he was too tired to climb out. Instead he tipped himself over the edge of the vitrine and dropped over the ten-foot drop to land on the stone floor of the sanctum.

Normally this action alone would be enough to kill someone, but Grizzlor had a thick skull and a determined mindset. That little princess was on her way out. He would make sure of that. He rose to his feet and made his way to the door of the Sanctum. At least the tar and kerosine had been dissolved by the amniotic fluids. The doors to the Sanctum opened but when he tried to walk through, they shut on his body making him scream out loud in a high-pitched screech of protest. After a few attempts at crushing his internal organs, the doors opening and closing repeatedly, they finally relented and eased back to their open housing positions. Grizzlor sagged to the floor in a heap.

"Oh, we're not tired, are we?"

He looked up, in trepidation and deep concern on his face, and saw Frosta standing at his head. She held the datapad in her hands, evidently giving her control of the doors and all systems of the Fright Zone alongside maps and blueprints. He growled, and

then stopped short. She had something she wasn't supposed to have.

"What… what's that?" he squeaked.

"Oh this? Don't worry, it's just a tiny little thing I found lying around on the floor."

Grizzlor stared at her in horror and then leapt to his feet to run off back into the sanctum. He hid behind the nearest vitrine, gasping for breath. Footsteps entered the huge room at a slow, steady pace… then stopped short.

Grizzlor panicked and searched the room with his eyes for a way out. The sanctum was a mess. Evidently it hadn't been cleaned up at all since Hordak and Catra had last fought each other. There was a huge gaping hole in the far end of the room, the floor, wall and ceiling of that part blasted away as though a bomb had hit it. Knowing them, it probably had. The only other exit was back to the door he'd just been through or into the throne room. He couldn't see Frosta. It worried him. The thing she carried…

He started back towards the doorway to the corridor and screamed as he ran into Tongue Lashor who had followed Frosta.

"Grizzlor, get a grip!" He put a hand on Grizzlor's shoulder and felt something slimy, "What in the…?"

"It's amniotic fluid. From the vitrine…"

"Oh, for star's sake Grizzlor! You are disgusting. You know that's like Hordak's spit right? You've been swimming in Hordak's spit. Stars above, you are the most disgusting person I've ever… ugh!"

"I'm sorry Tongue Lashor. See I had to … uh oh."

"Uh, oh? What's uh, oh?"

"Umm…" he pointed over his shoulder. Tongue Lashor tutted and rolled his eyes…

“This better be important.”

… and turned. Frosta stood in the doorway, Hordak’s arm cannon pointed directly at them with the full beam armed and ready.

“You’ve just been Frostbitten!”

The beam brightened to a sickening white so bright the men were forced to close their eyes tight against the onslaught. They were thrown high into the air by the blast that tossed them into the cavernous hole and down into the dungeons below. These were not Horde prison cells but far older, colder, darker and wetter, the stone surface halting their flight in an abrupt and painful manner. They lay there, stunned and winded, trying to get their breath back. Frosta’s face peered over the lip of the hole.

“Oh, you guys need some beauty sleep?”

Grizzlor lunged at her from the ground, leaping to his feet in an instant.

“You come down here and say that!”

She laughed, “Oh no, I’m so scared. You better come up and catch me.” She disappeared into the room and was gone.

Tongue Lashor took more time standing back up. He beckoned to Grizzlor and climbed up onto his shoulders. He reached for the edge of the next level so he could climb back up to the sanctum. Once there, he reached down for Grizzlor and then stiffened. The sound of a reload was unmistakable.

“You know, there’s a reason I waited for you to get back up here.”

He turned round slowly… and screamed. Frosta once more released the charge on the arm cannon blasting Tongue Lashor back down into the same hole in a white-hot light. Grizzlor, grabbing hold of the edge, pulled himself up just in time to come eye to eye with the Ice Maiden.

“Hiya…” she blasted him back down to land on top of Tongue Lashor, crushing him and causing him to go cross-eyed.

Frosta smiled down at the arm cannon, “Awesome. No wonder Hordak loved this thing. If I had one of these, I’d never take it off!”

She turned to leave, to put in place the final part of her plan, when she slipped on an errant piece of ice she’d forgotten about when laying her traps. Of all the things to flummox her, it had to be ice! Her own ice too. She slid, her arms thrown up into the air and landed on her back and head, hard enough to knock her out. The arm cannon smashed on impact, broken and useless.

She came to, a moment gone, to find Grizzlor and Tongue Lashor staring down at her, smiling ominously, victoriously.

“Well, well, what do we got here?” Tongue Lashor smirked. His mouthful of razor-sharp teeth glinted in the dim light. They hauled her up from the floor and dragged her out of the sanctum, each one holding a hand each so she couldn’t use her magic. Tongue Lashor grabbed the datapad from her and they led her higher and higher into the tallest parts of the Fright Zone.

“Looks like this is where you were headed for,” Tongue Lashor said, following the datapad. They found themselves on a high platform high above the industrialised area. A makeshift zipline had been anchored to the edge, a winged horse clearly waiting at the other end. It was too far away for Swift Wind to realise anything was amiss. Tongue Lashor looked carefully at the line and the datapad and laughed,

“Looks like your little plan didn’t work. You cut the line halfway. Anyone heavier than you wouldn’t make it. Nice work little princess.”

Grizzlor pulled Frosta back from the edge and held her tight by the lower arms. Tongue Lashor glanced once more at the datapad then tossed it roughly from the highest point to smash into tiny

pieces on the ground below. Frosta hoped beyond hope that the timed message had gone through. She looked up with a coy smirk.

“That was Dryl’s Scrolls by the way. Entrapta digitised them… and you just destroyed them.”

“What?” Grizzlor screamed in dismay as Tongue Lashor hung his head in frustration.

“You’re going to pay for this!”

The two men grabbed Frosta by an arm each, still preventing her from using her magic, and hauled her up onto the thin railing on the edge of the balcony. She gasped, eyes wide and she grabbed the railing tight. If she used ice now, they’d drop her. They’d drop her anyway. If she fell, maybe she could make an ice slide? Grizzlor moved in closer to speak and she felt herself tip backwards ever so slightly…

“If I were you princess, I’d remember who’s in charge here.”

She suddenly felt so very alone.

Chapter 6: Home Again

Chapter Summary

> The Scary Bandits have captured Frosta and she's out of ideas...

Frosta perched on the edge of the thin railing, hanging on tight as the Scary Bandits pressed their necks forward. She was already leaning back a little too far and any more could destabilise her beyond the point of no return.

Just then a strange voice cackled and warbled a train of nonsense vocabulary and a broom handle whacked each of the men out of Frosta's way. She hopped back onto the platform to find Madame Razz beating the two miscreants with her broomstick and shouting encouragement towards her.

"Go, my Frosta! Use the slide, and hurry up about it. Lookee is waiting for you!"

She turned back to her task, ushering Grizzlor and Tongue Lashor back inside the building and the stairs beyond. Frosta didn't waste any time. She leapt for the zip slide and hurled herself onto the waiting handlebars. She flew through the air at breakneck speed, the wind whistling through her hair and around her now filthy blue coat. Far below, she saw the Brightmoon skiffs and Landers filled with Brightmoon guards. Juliet, at the helm of the foremost vehicle, shouted out orders as she arrived at the central plaza of the Fright Zone. Frosta felt her chest relax knowing her anonymous message had gotten through to Juliet and that the General had believed her. From her unique position she saw them all fan out and take up positions around every exit and entry point as far as she could see. There would be no escape for the Scary Bandits.

She grinned at the thrill of the ride, her lucky escapes and the fun she'd had beating up the bad guys while protecting her planet.

She landed with a soft thud and straightened her clothing and hair. Swift Wind trotted over.

"Hey, Frosta. How'd it go? I was getting worried there, you took so long."

She waved him off with a hand, "Meh, you don't have to worry about me. I got it covered."

"My Frosta, saviour of the world!" Madame Razz appeared from behind a tree and hugged the youngest princess with a tear in her eye. "You always worry Madame Razz, you naughty girl. You need to be more careful next time."

"Uh, there's a next time?" Swift Wind sounded concerned. Frosta smirked.

"Of course there's a next time. Winter's Bane never fails to defeat her opponents… with Ice Fists!" She thought for a moment and then turned back to Madame Razz but the old woman had disappeared into thin air. "Huh, where'd she go?"

"Where'd who go? Oh, the old lady? Oh, she left, and so should we unless you want to go back to Brightmoon? You know that's where Juliet will take you if you stay here."

He waited, patiently as Frosta made up her mind. It had been fun chasing bad guys and generally doing things she wasn't really supposed to do but… something caught her eye and she looked up to see Darla returning to the planet. It was still far off but there was no mistaking it's destination, the Fright Zone.

"Aw, frosticles. I'm still not apologising. Swift Wind, just take me home, I need time by myself, properly by myself."

She leapt up onto his back and he flexed his wings, pulling them into the sky in a burst of energy and strength so powerful that Frosta felt her stomach lurch in delight giving her tummy tickles and she laughed despite herself. Swift Wind smiled and they

soared off into the distance back home, to the Kingdom of Snows and a nice cup of hot chocolate.

*****

Glimmer marched down the gangplank of Darla's loading bay ramp and located General Juliet in a trice. She raced over; breath ragged with concern and pulled at the older woman's cloak.

"General Juliet, what's happening? Where's Frosta?"

"My Queen, I apologise. Please forgive me. I handled things rashly and Frosta… I have yet to locate her."

Two Brightmoon Guards walked past, escorting a cuffed Tongue Lashor and Grizzlor who growled at Glimmer as he walked past,

"Hey, tell that Princess Frosta to be careful. When we get out of jail, she better watch her back, cuz the Scary Bandits will be chewing on it." Tongue Lashor glared at him.

"Shut up Grizzlor! That's the Queen, show some respect, and we're not the Scary Bandits, it sounds stupid."

Glimmer watched, eyebrows raised, as the two dishevelled, burned and slightly ridiculous-looking men were manhandled off towards the skiffs and back to Brightmoon for questioning. She looked to Juliet for answers.

"We had an anonymous call about two thieves who have been stealing Etherian treasures from every kingdom. Apparently, they were planning to take over the Fright Zone too, until our intel sent a message telling us to get here now. We've already arrested or scared off several would-be infiltrators from both the Crimson Waste and the old Horde Order. I'll keep a guard posted for the foreseeable future until we regain command of the region."

Glimmer nodded at General Juliet's efficiency. "Excellent work, Juliet. Do you have any idea who the anonymous informer might be?"

She had her suspicions of course but all she received in reply was a small smile, a wink and a nod.

“Ah, and where might Princess Frosta be?”

Juliet shrugged, a sad look on her face, “I’m afraid I’ve been unable to locate the princess for some time.”

There was a pause as Glimmer took in the new information. She had to find Frosta, she needed to know her friend was safe. She thought for a moment and then her eyes lit up.

“I know where she is.”

Without another word she teleported away. General Juliet returned to her duties without so much as a blink.

*****

Frosta settled into her bed of cushions and plush toys, a mug of hot chocolate and some ice cream and cookies sitting next to it. Swift Wind had taken her home and then left to check in with Adora. She sighed in contentment but something still nagged at her inside. Had all those pranks really been funny? Had it been worth it? She thought so but that nagging inside the pit of her stomach just wouldn’t go away. she picked up her book once more, Mermysteries, The Tail of the Sunken Siren, but she couldn’t concentrate. She didn’t want to say sorry but she wanted her friends back.

A pink shimmer appeared in the room and Frosta gulped as she realised Queen Glimmer had arrived. She tensed for a lecture and opened her mouth to object but the queen’s face was, instead, a mask of concern.

“Frosta! I’ve been so worried. I’m so sorry we left you behind. I thought you were on the ship.”

Frosta glowered at Glimmer, remembering how isolated she had felt being the youngest on board.

“Yeah, well I did fine without you. Did just fine before we even met too.”

Glimmer scowled at the girl but then her face softened into a smile and she sat next to her in the cushion pile.

“You’re right Frosta. You don’t need us. You’re the most competent princess of us all. You have done things I could never have achieved at your age. But you don’t have to be alone anymore. You have us, and we care. We all do. Perfuma, Catra and Scorpia were beside themselves when they realised you weren’t on the ship and Entrapta hasn’t sleep at all trying to get back here as fast as possible. Even Mermista showed a bit of remorse at the things she said.”

Frosta looked into Glimmer’s eyes but she still felt that ache in the pit of her stomach. She sighed; it had to be done.

“I’m sorry too. I just wanted a bit of fun. You guys are always off doing your own thing. I get a little lonely sometimes.”

“And that’s our fault. We should have included you better. What if we plan a new trip to someplace fun, you can choose, and we all just relax for a change. No kingdoms, no workloads, just fun.” She smiled warmly and Frosta launched into a hug so tight Glimmer squealed.

“Thanks Glimmer. You’re the best!”

Glimmer’s datapad bleeped and she giggled as she clicked it on.

“Glimmer, we’ve secured the Fright Zone and rounded up all the bad guys. How’s Frosta?” Bow smiled and waved at the young princess as she pushed her head into view.

Frosta opened her mouth to speak just as cries of despair rose up from the background. Mermista and Perfuma came into view, pushing Bow aside as they spoke in a torrent of anger and frustration.

“Frosta!” Mermista growled, “You destroyed the Salinean Pearls!”

“And the Seeds of Plumeria, they were irreplaceable!”

“I’m going to destroy you Frosta!”

“Hey,” Glimmer soothed, “I think that in the circumstances Frosta did save us all from the Scary Bandits and…”

“She destroyed the Brightmoon Lantern of Light,” Mermista cut in. Glimmer’s face grew pale. She looked at Frosta’s face, questioning. Frosta looked up at her with a guilty expression.

“It was… I needed to…”

“Wait, you guys didn’t back up your kingdoms treasures?” Entrapta’s cheery voice in the background did nothing to relieve the tensions in the atmosphere, “You should always back up your data! The Dryl scrolls have been backed up multiple times over!”

“I can’t back up priceless pearls.”

“Actually, you coooould make replicas, grow them artificially…”

“There’s no way to ‘back up’ seeds. They are precious life…”

“That lantern was a family heirloom. There’s nothing like it anywhere else in the universe.”

A scream erupted from the datapad. Scorpia could be heard of in the distance, wailing about graffiti and melted crown jewels.

Frosta gulped. She pulled the mimic crystal from her pocket and lifted it to her lips.

“I’ll eh, I’ll just be going,” said Double Trouble’s voice, “Don’t want to intrude here.”

She slid away as Mermista and Perfuma ranted over their losses and Entrapta babbled incoherently behind them. Glimmer’s face

became a mask of incomprehension as the devastation became clear to her. She looked up and Frosta stopped by the doorway.

“Um… I think I hear Swift Wind calling me…”

“Frosta!”

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